ROBE REVERSAL



Ex-CM **Mamata Banerjee's** turn as a lawyer at the Calcutta High Court on May 14—arguing a case linked to attacks on her Trinamool Congress partymen and their offices—has not gone down well with the Bar Council of India (BCI). The BCI has now demanded details of Mamata's enrolment and practice status from its Bengal wing. In February, she had made history as the first sitting CM to argue in the Supreme Court, challenging the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in Bengal. Strangely, that had not ruffled feathers at the BCI. Guess loss of power also leads to loss of influence in other areas.



Trading Places

With assembly polls less than a year away, Punjab's politics is hotting up. After seven of its MPs jumped ship and joined the BJP last month, Arvind Kejriwal's Aam Aadmi Party has snared ex-Akali Dal minister **Surjit Singh Rakhra**. But Rakhra and his brother, the US-based Sikh billionaire Darshan Singh Dhaliwal, have also had a curious relationship with the BJP. Dhaliwal was stopped at the Delhi airport and turned back in 2021, allegedly for supporting the farmers' protest over the farm laws. But after the repeal of the farm laws, both brothers were active in the BJP's global Sikh outreach.

PERFORMANCE ANXIETY



Ministers in the Andhra Pradesh cabinet can breathe a little easier. CM **N. Chandrababu Naidu** has decided to spare them the public scrutiny and ridicule over their performance rankings, which were based on how quickly ministers cleared e-files. Media reports of the rankings had caused some discomfort within the coalition regime. Deputy CM **Pawan Kalyan's** Jana Sena Party had not taken kindly to news of their chief's falling scores. With the party going public with its misgivings, Naidu possibly felt that a bit more circumspection was needed.



Kaushik Deka* with *Ashish Misra, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar* and *Prasad Nichenametla

ECO WATCH

WILD WATER BUFFALOES FROM KAZIRANGA TO KANHA

By **Jumana Shah**

In late April, four subadult Asiatic wild water buffaloes (a male and three females) were loaded into specialised transport vehicles at Kaziranga and driven over 2,000 kilometres to Kanha Tiger Reserve in Madhya Pradesh's Supkhar forest range in Balaghat district. It is the longest wildlife translocation in Indian history, and the first batch of an eventual 50 animals.

Bubalus arnee is a critically endangered animal, with a global wild population of under 4,000, 99 per cent of them concentrated in Assam. Central India, where these buffaloes once roamed widely, has not seen one since 1979, when Kanha had its last confirmed sighting. Wild buffaloes are 'grassland engineers', meaning their grazing maintains the open mosaic that tigers, swamp deer and barasingha depend on. Bringing them back rebuilds a missing ecological function, not just a charismatic species. MP has signalled it will return the favour by sending gharials to Assam, where the endangered crocodilian has all but vanished from the Brahmaputra.



Meanwhile, there is some trepidation over how it all happened so speedily, with the chief ministers of both states getting involved. Translocation is a delicate science. Animals can carry pathogens across landscapes, founder populations can collapse from inbreeding, and politics can potentially override scientific caution. Environmentalists caution against swaps driven by optics rather than ecology.

As of now, the buffaloes have been soft-released into a controlled enclosure at Supkhar. Whether they thrive or not will tell us if India has found a new template for inter-state species swaps that could reshape conservation efforts, or just a faster way to repeat old mistakes.